TECHNICAL REPORT

Implementing Security Features and Governance / Administration Practices in Zoho Creator

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1. Abstract

Zoho Creator helps people build business apps quickly. But an app that stores customer data must also be safe. This report explains how to set up security and manage an app properly in Zoho Creator. It covers three main areas. The first is protecting the sign-in, using strong passwords, a second verification step, allowed IP addresses and single sign-on. The second is controlling what each person can see and do, using permissions, roles and data sharing rules. The third is managing the app over time, using test environments, audit trails, backups and user clean-up. An insurance claims app is used as an example. The report ends with an action plan, some limits to keep in mind, and simple tips.

2. Introduction

Low-code tools let one person build and publish an app in a few days. This is useful, but it also brings risk. A form that collects names, phone numbers, policy numbers and claim amounts could be shared with the wrong person. Someone could change a record and nobody would know. A new change could go live before anyone has tested it. The faster apps are built, the more important clear rules become.

Two ideas help here. Security means keeping data safe from people who should not see it. It answers: who can sign in, from where, and what can they do? Governance means looking after the app over time. It answers: how are users added and removed, how are changes tested, and how do we keep a record of what happened?

This report explains the tools Zoho Creator offers for both, shows how they work together in a real example, and points out the limits an administrator should know about.

3. How Security Works in Zoho Creator

Zoho Creator protects an app in layers, like a building with several locked doors. The first layer decides who can enter. The second decides what a person can do inside. The third decides which records the person can see. Another set of tools helps manage the app itself. Table 1 shows these layers.

Layer	Zoho Creator Feature	What It Does
Sign-in protection	Security policies (password rules, multi-factor authentication, IP limits, session limits) and single sign-on	Lets only the right people in, from the right places
What users can do	Permissions for forms, reports, pages and fields	Decides which parts of the app each person can use
Which records users see	Roles, role hierarchy, peer sharing and data sharing rules	Decides which records each person can see

Layer	Zoho Creator Feature	What It Does
Safe changes	Environments: Development, Stage and Production	Lets you test changes before real users see them
Tracking and recovery	Audit trails, automatic backups, app diagnostics	Records activity and helps you recover data

Table 1: Layers of security in Zoho Creator

Zoho explains that its permission system gives detailed control over who can view and manage the data in an app. There are two default permissions, Read and Write. You can also create custom permissions that allow view, edit or delete access for each form. Zoho suggests using permissions, role hierarchy and data sharing rules together for the best control.

4. Example Application: Insurance Claim Request & Processing Management

4.1 About the App

The example is the Insurance Claim Request & Processing Management app. Its Claim_Request_Form collects the claimant's name, claimant type and policy number. It also collects email, phone number and address. Then it collects the claim type, date of incident, amount requested, supporting documents and a short description. A declaration box confirms the information is true. A report lists all claims. A Claims_Dashboard page shows the total claims, total and average claim amount, and charts by claim type and claimant type.

Almost every field here is sensitive. Names, phone numbers and addresses identify a person. Claim amounts and descriptions show their money and personal situation. This is why security must be planned carefully for this app.

4.2 Suggested User Groups

Before changing any setting, list who will use the app and what each person really needs. Table 2 shows a suggested list.

Role	Who They Are	What They Can Access
Administrator	App owner or IT lead	All settings, users and releases; does not handle claims daily
Claims Manager	Senior claims officer	All claims in the team; can edit status and amounts; sees the dashboard
Claims Officer	Front-line staff member	Only the claims they handle; no settings and no exports
Auditor	Compliance or audit staff	Read-only view of reports and the audit trail
Claimant (outside user)	Policyholder or nominee	Can submit a claim and see only their own claim

Table 2: Suggested user groups for the claims app

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5. Setting Up Security Features

5.1 Sign-In Protection with Security Policies

Security policies in Zoho Creator work through Zoho Directory. They let an administrator ask for strong passwords, turn on multi-factor authentication (MFA), allow sign-in only from certain IP addresses, and set session time limits. Zoho states that security policies are available only on paid plans. This is important if you are using a trial or free account.

A good starting setup for the claims app is:

- **Strong passwords.** Set a minimum length and a mix of letters, numbers and symbols.
- **Multi-factor authentication.** Ask for a second check when signing in. Start with Administrators and Claims Managers.
- **IP restrictions.** Allow staff to sign in only from the office network or company VPN. Then a stolen password alone is not enough.
- **Session limits.** End idle sessions quickly and limit how many sessions a user can have open. This protects data if someone leaves a computer unlocked.

One tip from Zoho's guide: if a user has allowed one IP address in their own account and the security policy allows a different one, only the policy's address works. Test every policy with a spare account first so no one is locked out.

5.2 Single Sign-On and Directory Connection

Some organisations already keep staff accounts in another system. Zoho Directory can use that system for single sign-on (SSO) through SAML, so users do not need a new password. It can also connect to Active Directory or LDAP using a sync tool. This helps in two ways. Users have one login to remember. And when a person leaves and their main account is switched off, their access to Zoho Creator stops at the same time.

5.3 Permissions for Forms, Reports and Fields

Permissions decide what a signed-in user can do. At module level, the administrator chooses which forms, reports and pages a person can open. At field level, the administrator chooses which fields a person can view and which they can edit. For example, a Claims Officer may open the claims report but may not change the Policy_Number after submission. An Auditor may view every field but change none.

Table 3 shows how this could look in the claims app. These values are a suggested design, not a finished setup.

Part of the App	Claims Officer	Claims Manager	Auditor	Claimant
Claim_Request_Form (submit)	Yes	Yes	No	Yes

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Part of the App	Claims Officer	Claims Manager	Auditor	Claimant
Claim_Request_Form Report	Own claims	All claims	All, read-only	Own claim only
Claims_Dashboard	No	Yes	Yes	No
Contact and address fields	View	View, edit	View	Own only
Claim_Amount_Requested	View, edit	View, edit	View	Own only
Delete records	No	No	No	No
Export data	No	Limited	Yes	No

Table 3: Suggested permission table

This follows the rule of least privilege: give each person only the access they need. No one can delete records, so nothing disappears quietly. Corrections are made by editing, and the audit trail records each edit.

5.4 Roles and Role Hierarchy

Permissions say what a person can do. Roles say where the person fits in the organisation. Roles let you copy your company structure into Creator. When role hierarchy is turned on, a person higher up can see their own records and the records added by the people below them. In the claims app, a Claims Manager would see the claims entered by their officers. Each officer would not see their colleagues' claims.

Creator can also share data with peers, so people at the same level can see each other's records. Turn this on only when the team truly needs it, because it makes more data visible.

5.5 Data Sharing Rules

Real organisations do not always follow a strict ladder. Data sharing rules handle the exceptions. A rule shares the records of a report from one user or role to another. Zoho says these rules override the role hierarchy. For example, a Fraud Review role could be given only the high-value claims, no matter who entered them.

Sharing rules add access; they do not remove it. So every rule should have a reason, an owner and a review date. A rule made for a one-time check and then forgotten is a common cause of accidental exposure.

5.6 Protecting Personal Information

The permissions area has settings for fields marked as personal information (PII) or health information (ePHI). The administrator can choose whether these marked fields are visible by default or whether their visibility cannot be selected. In the claims app, contact details, address and policy number would be marked as sensitive. New roles then start with these fields hidden and get access only when it is clearly needed.

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6. Administration and Governance Practices

6.1 Environments and Safe Releases

Creator's Environments feature gives a safe path for changes. The app is edited in Development, tested in Stage, and then published to Production, where real users work. Data in each environment is kept separately, so test records never mix with real claims. Table 4 explains the three stages.

Environment	Purpose	Typical Work
Development	The only place where the app is edited; can also be opened for early testing	Building forms, reports and permissions
Stage	Testing changes before they go live	Checking roles and workflows with demo users
Production	The live app used by real users	Daily claim processing

Table 4: Environments in Zoho Creator

This matters for security, because a permission change can also go wrong. Testing a new role in Stage first stops a mistake from exposing real claim data. Zoho lists two limits. Creator cannot hold more than 30 versions at once in Stage across all apps, so versions must be moved on to Production. Also, approval workflows and data sharing with specific users cannot be tested in Development or Stage, so take extra care when releasing them.

6.2 Audit Trails

An audit trail is a time-ordered record of what users did in the app. Each entry shows who did the action, what it was, when it happened and which data it touched. In a claims system it answers questions like: who changed this claim amount, and when was the status edited?

Keeping the record is only half the job. Someone must read it. An administrator or auditor should check it on a regular schedule, for example every week for changes to amounts and statuses, and straight away after any security problem.

6.3 Backups, Diagnostics and Updates

Creator makes automatic backups of app data, offers app diagnostics to help keep apps running well, and applies new features and security fixes automatically. This reduces the vendor-side workload, but the administrator still has jobs to do. Know how to ask for a restore, check that restores work, and test key forms and reports after each update.

6.4 Managing Users Over Time

Many security problems come from people, not technology. Old accounts are never removed, or permissions slowly grow. A simple routine prevents this:

- **New user:** give the role that matches the job, and nothing extra.
- **Job change:** change the role instead of adding a new one on top.

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- **Person leaves:** switch off the account the same day, ideally through the central directory.
- **Every three months:** review users, roles and sharing rules, and remove what is not needed.

6.5 Domain and Email Safety

Creator uses domain authentication so that only genuine domains can access the app. It also supports the email checks SPF, DKIM and DMARC. This matters because the claims app sends emails to claimants. These checks help real emails reach the inbox and make fake emails harder to pass off as yours.

7. Step-by-Step Implementation Plan

Table 5 turns the ideas above into an ordered plan. The basics (users and roles) come first, before any real data is added or real users are invited.

Step	Action	Where in Creator	Result
1	List user groups and the data each one needs	Planning document	Agreed roles (Table 2)
2	Set a security policy: passwords, MFA, IP limits, sessions	Security policies (Zoho Directory)	Protected sign-in for staff
3	Connect the identity provider, if there is one	SAML single sign-on or directory sync	One login per person
4	Create roles and turn on role hierarchy	Users and roles	Managers see their team's records
5	Set permissions for forms, reports and fields	Permissions	Least-privilege access (Table 3)
6	Add data sharing rules only for exceptions	Data sharing rules	Documented exceptions with owners
7	Test everything in Stage with demo users	Environments	Checked before going live
8	Publish to Production and start audit checks	Environments, audit trail	Live and monitored app
9	Review users, rules and logs every three months	Admin routine	Access stays correct

Table 5: Implementation plan

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8. Challenges and Limitations

A fair report should also say where these tools need care or fall short.

- **Plan limits.** Security policies need a paid plan. On a trial account, MFA and IP restrictions may not be available.
- **Testing gaps.** Approval workflows and sharing with specific users cannot be tested in Development or Stage, so part of the access setup is only checked after release.

- **Rules that overlap.** Permissions, role hierarchy, peer sharing and sharing rules affect each other. Because sharing rules override the hierarchy, a wrong mix can give someone too much access. Test each change with a user who has that role.
- **Depending on the vendor.** Zoho handles backups, patches and upgrades. This is convenient, but proof for auditors must come from Zoho's documents. Check Zoho's published compliance and data-location details instead of assuming.
- **Human mistakes.** No setting stops someone from sharing a password or saving data on a personal device. Training and clear rules are also needed.

9. Best Practices and Recommendations

- **Plan access first.** Decide roles and sensitive fields before building forms.
- **Give least access.** Start with little and add more only when asked.
- **Protect administrators most.** Require MFA for every administrator and keep their number small.
- **Never test in Production.** Change in Development, check in Stage, then publish.
- **Write down every exception.** Note the reason, owner and review date for each special rule.
- **Read the audit trail regularly.** Give the task to a named person and a fixed schedule.
- **Remove leavers quickly.** Switch off accounts on the last working day.
- **Check Zoho's evidence.** Read the current security and compliance pages before storing regulated data, and keep a copy.

10. Conclusion

Zoho Creator gives administrators layered tools to protect apps and manage them well. Security policies, MFA, IP limits and single sign-on protect the sign-in. Permissions, roles and sharing rules control what each person can do and see. Environments, audit trails and backups keep the app organised and accountable. The claims app example shows these tools work best when planned together: decide roles first, give the least access, test before release, and review activity often.

Still, tools alone are not enough. Plan limits, testing gaps, overlapping rules and human mistakes remain. Organisations that treat security as an ongoing habit, not a one-time setup, can enjoy the speed of low-code without putting their data at risk.

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